party base where grumblers and complainers made their voices heard. Ceasing to pay dues was the preferred form of passive resignation.21

In loyally championing the repute of the KPD in the Sputnik debacle, Honecker did his own reputation untold harm with the public, SED members and Gorbachev. Honecker explained in 1991:

The Sputnik decision was very emotional and not carried out because of our overall policy with regard to the Soviet Union. It was outrageous, and I still find that today, that communists were blamed. Those who did everything in illegality to bring into existence a movement for the overthrow of Hitler and who suffered great sacrifices were to be blamed for the outbreak of the Second World War!22

In the summer of 1988, Honecker's mood was further aggravated during a visit to the Soviet Union where he witnessed discontent and flux. After a visit to Magnitogorsk, he privately scoffed:

The immediate feeling of the people there gave the definite impression that with perestroika, the economic position had not become better but worse, productivity had risen but there was no salt nor sugar, nor flour nor meat, all the things that people needed to live … living standards had not improved but had worsened.23

In a conversation with Gorbachev, he recalled with heavy sarcasm the success of the five-year plans when he was last in Magnitogorsk in the 1930s.24 By this point, the Soviet leader was lumping Honecker in with Bulgaria's Todor Zhivkov, Czechoslovakia's Gustáv Husák and Romania's Nicolae Ceaușescu as the so-called 'Gang of Four': a group of crusty, out-of-touch, inflexible unregenerated Stalinists unwilling to make reforms.25